

2.3 MILLION

THE NUMBER OF **BLOCKS** USED TO BUILD THE GREAT PYRAMID OF GIZA



The three pyramids at Giza were built for the pharaohs Khufu, Khafra, and Menkaura between 2575 and 2465 BCE. They are guarded by the statue of the Sphinx, which may bear the features of King Khafra.



Standard of Ur

This boxlike object has two side panels—one depicting war, the other (shown here) times of peace.

SOUTHERN MESOPOTAMIA was a patchwork of over 40 city-states, among which Ur, Uruk, Nippur, and Kish were the most important. **Trade flourished** using a network of rivers and canals, and trade links extended to Anatolia (modern-day Turkey), Iran, and Afghanistan, with grain, minerals, lumber, tools, and vessels traded. The **Sumerian** population was unique in being **predominantly urban**. In Ur, Uruk, and other centers, people lived in clustered mud-brick houses. At the heart of the city, the **ziggurat**—a terraced temple

mound—provided the focus for religious ceremonies, and grain was kept in storerooms within the temple precincts. From around 2500 BCE, some citizens of Ur were buried in **tombs** along with treasures such as the **Standard of Ur**. The purpose of its intricate



side panels is still a mystery; they may have formed the soundbox of a lyre.

Arising from the need to keep economic and administrative records, the **first pictographic writing** developed in **Sumer** (c. 3300 BCE). Pictographs (pictorial writing representing a word or phrase) evolved into a script called **cuneiform** c. 2900 BCE, in which scribes pressed sharpened reeds into soft clay to leave wedge-shaped impressions.

Southern Mesopotamia became densely populated, putting pressure on natural

Cuneiform tablet

Over time, the inventory of signs regularly used in cuneiform script was greatly reduced.

resources. This led to **conflicts** over land and water, and alliances between cities were forged and broken.

The first signs of **civilization in the Americas** appeared along the coast of Peru and in the Andes c. 2800 BCE. **Andean farmers** grew potatoes and the cereal quinoa, and raised alpacas and llamas. There were fishing communities on the coast, while inland towns became ceremonial centers, built around mud-brick temple platforms. An exceptional example is **Caral**, about 125 miles (200 km) from Lima and dating from c. 2600 BCE. Another, **Aspero**, had six platform mounds topped by temples. Cotton was grown in the region, and corn was cultivated from around 2700 BCE.

The **Indus Valley civilization** began to emerge in South Asia in the fourth millennium BCE, as **flood control technology** developed. By 2600 BCE, the Indus Plain contained dozens of towns and cities. Of these, **Mohenjo-daro** on the Indus River, and **Harappa**, to the northeast, were preeminent, with populations of around 100,000 and 60,000, respectively.

In **Egypt**, King Sanakht acceded to the throne in the year 2686 BCE, marking the beginning of the Third dynasty and the **Old Kingdom** era—a time of strong, centralized rule and **pyramid-building**.

These magnificent monuments were built as **royal tombs**. In Early Dynastic times, kings had been buried beneath rectangular mud-brick platforms called **mastabas**. Around 2650 BCE, the first pyramid, the **Step Pyramid of Saqqara**, was completed for King Djoser. Designed by the architect Imhotep, it resembled six stone mastabas on top of one another.

Straight-sided pyramids appeared soon after, the greatest of which were the **three pyramids at Giza**. These incredible feats of engineering were constructed not by slaves as was once thought, but by a staff of full-time craftsmen and masons supplemented by farmers performing a type of national service during the Nile floods. Enormous blocks of stone (lower stones of 6–10 tons; higher ones of 1–2 tons) were cut from local quarries, hauled on site using sleds, and then heaved up ramps, which grew ever higher as construction progressed.

